

relies on the crayfish and rice of the bayous and the piquant tabasco strain of chili pepper. In fact, native North American peppers in their hundreds of varieties could be said to be the taste of the continent. The pork rib barbecue of Memphis carries just a hint of chili pepper heat, while in San Antonio, Texas, spicy stewed-beef chili contains nearly as much hot pepper as meat. But capsicum peppers have many more qualities than sheer heat: the sweetness of pimientos, the smokiness of chipotle, and the spicy, fruity flavors of the habanero, for example. Farther up the Rio Grande, these are wonderfully exploited in the subtle cuisine of New Mexico, where Spanish colonists married Native American corn tortillas and chili-pepper-based sauces with an old-world taste for meat fillings.

Overseas Influences

A similar collusion between Native American and Spanish cookery took place in Mexico, where the people of Puebla combined their indigenous heritage ingredients of chocolate and chili pepper with spices introduced by the Spanish to create the rich brown sauce called *mole*. Indeed, it is a rare dish in Mexico that does not contain

some form of chili pepper; it forms a part of even the *taco al pastor*, or rotisserie taco, so similar to the Middle Eastern doner kebab. The hottest of all the capsicums – the Scotch bonnet pepper found throughout the Caribbean basin – electrifies Jamaican jerk cooking, lending both heat and citrus notes to the smoky, spicy tang of Jamaican pimento wood, from the shrub that yields allspice. While jerk meat (usually chicken or fish) can be traced back to the original Arawak inhabitants of Jamaica, other Caribbean specialties reflect the islands' cultural overlays. So many East Asians were relocated to the Caribbean islands during colonial times that curries, *aloo* (spicy potato dishes), and the friendship bread of *dosti roti* are standards in the West Indies.

The African diaspora played a profound role in North American cooking as well. African slaves in the cotton and sugar cane regions of the American South cooked with African provender – okra, peanuts, and melons – along with leafy greens and cheap cuts of pork. In time, the hearty fare became known as “soul food,” from collard greens cooked in bacon fat to the unctuous sweet potato pie.

Americans have always had a sweet tooth, whether for thick cheesecakes made with the cream cheese of Philadelphia or for the sweet pastries of Pennsylvania Dutch country. A farming society with roots in central Europe (where pastry is king), Pennsylvania Dutch cooks are wont to encase every berry or tree fruit they grow in a flaky crust. It is, as the saying goes, as American as apple pie.

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Left Local produce for sale at a market in Guadalajara, Mexico

Below A love of cars and fast food came together perfectly in the creation of the diner

